



THE SACRED DIVIDE

Sunni Islam

Islam family

HONOR THE FAITH · NAME THE MACHINERY

~87-90% of Muslims; authority located in the Qur'an, Sunnah, scholarly consensus, and four major legal schools; no single head.

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How to read this

Every religion in The Sacred Divide is laid out the same way, in the same 27 sections, so that any section can be compared across religions. This file examines institutions, offices, money and power. It does not judge anyone's faith or the truth of any belief.

Evidence grades

Each of the 30 techniques carries a grade for how it is established in this tradition.

- **CODIFIED** Written policy, published rule, contractual requirement, or a procedure the institution has confirmed in its own documents. The strongest grade and the hardest to deny.
- **DOCUMENTED** Established by court judgment, government inquiry, regulatory action, or financial filing. Not the institution's own words, but a body with subpoena power.
- **TAUGHT** Repeated leadership instruction from platform, publication, or curriculum, without a formal rule. Deniable as emphasis rather than policy.
- **CULTURAL** Community enforcement the institution neither mandates nor prevents. Real in effect, unattributable by design – the highest-deniability grade.
- **CONTESTED** Occurs in some parts of the tradition and is actively opposed in others. Generalizing this grade across a whole tradition is a misuse of it.
- **REFORMED** Documented historically and materially changed since – policy withdrawn, practice ended, or independent oversight accepted. Recorded because omitting it would be dishonest.
- **UNGRADED** Present in the source material without a grade assigned yet. Read as an unverified pattern claim, not as a finding.

Receipts

Bracketed labels such as **OFFICIAL POLICY** name the kind of source a claim rests on.

- **Official policy.** The institution's own written rule: handbook, canon, policy letter, catechism, trust deed, temple recommend question. The strongest evidence available, because it cannot be attributed to a rogue individual.
- **Court record.** Judgments, convictions, filings, and testimony given under oath. Adversarially tested, which is more than most religious claims about themselves have been.
- **Government inquiry.** Royal commissions, grand juries, parliamentary and state investigations with subpoena power. Where these exist they are usually the best record of what an institution did rather than said.
- **Regulatory action.** Findings and penalties from bodies like the SEC or consumer-protection regulators. Narrow in scope, unusually precise in what they establish.
- **Financial record.** Filings, audited statements, tax returns, disclosed compensation, property transactions. Frequently the only place an institution tells the truth about its priorities.
- **Leadership statement.** Recorded sermons, conference addresses, published letters. The institution in its own voice, to its own people, on the record.
- **Independent investigation.** Reports commissioned by the institution but conducted externally. Weaker than a court and far stronger than a press release – and notable when the institution publishes them in full.
- **Academic source.** Peer-reviewed history, sociology, and demography. Best for context, structure, and scale; weaker for specific institutional conduct.
- **Former member testimony.** Firsthand accounts from people who were inside. Indispensable and interested at once – graded as testimony, never presented as documentary proof.
- **Pattern observed.** A recurring configuration with no single document behind it. Labeled as an observation rather than a finding, and the weakest claim type in this codex.

Method

- Separation of targets. This codex analyzes institutional control patterns, never the worth of believers or the truth of beliefs. Theology is out of scope; behavior, money, and power are in scope.
- Pattern over anecdote. A tactic is attributed to a tradition's high-control expressions only where the mechanism recurs – one bad congregation proves nothing; the same architecture in a hundred proves the architecture.
- Evidence weighting. Every factual claim carries a bracketed source-type label and should carry a grade (A–D). Claims marked **SOURCE NEEDED** or **PATTERN OBSERVED** are analysis, not established fact, and must not be published as fact.
- Steelman rule. Every tactic section presents the institution's strongest defense before countering it. If the defense cannot be stated in a form its adherents would recognize, the counter is not yet earned.
- Asymmetry honesty. Similar tactic does not mean identical severity. A shunning policy that costs your entire family is not the same as a community that cools toward doubters, and the codex must never flatten that difference.
- The mirror rule. Any framework this powerful can itself be misused – to smear traditions, flatter one's own, or manufacture grievance. The self-audit and language guardrails apply to this project as much as to any institution it examines.

Citations

A number in brackets, such as ¹², links to item 12 in this religion's Sources, at the end of the file. Every source was checked for this edition.

SECTION 01

At a glance

SIZE	About 1.7–1.8 billion (roughly 87–90% of Muslims). ACADEMIC SOURCE · Pew
WHO'S IN CHARGE	al-Azhar (Cairo) – the tradition's most cited seat of learning – Grand Imam Ahmed el-Tayeb, appointed by the president in 2010
CHOSEN BY / REMOVABLE BY	The Council of Senior Scholars (since 2012) / Nobody – the 2014 Constitution makes the office irremovable
MONEY IN ONE LINE	Same base flows as Islam generally; plus state salaries for clerics, Gulf endowments for institutions abroad, and celebrity-preacher media economies.
LEAVING IN ONE LINE	Community and family enforcement typically exceeds institutional enforcement; leaving or liberalizing costs marriage prospects, family standing, and in diaspora communities, one's entire social base. VARIES BY COMMUNITY
THE UNANSWERED QUESTION	Who accredits the scholars who decide who counts as a scholar – and why does that trail end at a ministry almost every time?
EVIDENCE	3 of 30 techniques sourced to a named document; grades: Cultural 15, Taught 11, Contested 4
FAMILY	Islam – islam, sunni-islam, shia-islam, ahmadiyya, dawoodi-bohra
LAST CHECKED	2026-09-27

— Disclosure scorecard

ACCOUNTS	PAY	SAFEGUARDING	EXTERNAL FIRST	REMOVAL	REPLY
P	N	P	P	N	N

Y Yes – established from a public source · **P** Partial – true of some parts of the tradition, or true in some jurisdictions · **N** No – not established from any public source · **?** Not assessable – no institutional apex exists to assess

SECTION 02

A day inside

Yusuf · A Tuesday in the school term · A South Asian city

He is nineteen and has been at the madrasa since he was seven. He can recite the entire Qur'an. He cannot fill out the form at the government office where his brother works, because it is in English, and this is a fact he has known about himself for two years and has told no one.

Morning revision at five. The younger boys sway over their texts. He loves this room. He loves the sound of it. He has been happy here in a way he does not think his brother has ever been happy anywhere.

At nine Qari Sahib canes a boy named Bilal for the third time this month, on the hands, and the room goes carefully quiet and then resumes. Yusuf has seen this for twelve years. He no longer registers it as an event. Afterward Bilal sits beside him and Yusuf gives him half his bread and neither of them says anything.

In the afternoon a man from the sponsoring foundation visits, and the boys line up, and there are photographs. The man's Arabic is better than the teachers'. Yusuf notices that the new books have arrived and that the new books say some things differently than the old books, and that nobody has remarked on this.

At six he walks past the school his cousin attends, the one with the computer room. He stands there for a moment. Then he goes home, where his mother has made his favourite thing, and where his father says with real pride that his son is a hafiz and that Allah has blessed this house.

At night on the roof he does something he does not do in front of anyone: he opens his brother's old English primer and works through eight words with a torch. It takes him forty minutes. He puts it back exactly where he found it. He is not certain whether what he is doing is ambition or betrayal, and there is nobody in the building he could ask.

SECTION 03

The forefront

You were probably taught there is no priest between you and God – and that is true, and it is the strongest thing you own. What you may not have been taught is how much of what governs your life was decided by men who were paid to decide it, in offices funded by governments, using a vocabulary of piety that makes their rulings hard to question out loud.

— The unanswered question

*Who accredits the scholars who decide who counts as a scholar
— and why does that trail end at a ministry almost every
time?*

— The widest gap between word and record

THEY SAY	THE RECORD SHOWS	RECEIPT
Scholars are independent of rulers.	Colonial and modern states seized the endowments that funded independence and replaced them with salaries.	ACADEMIC SOURCE

— One cost of leaving, beside its denial

COST	DOCUMENTED?	DETAIL	THE OFFICIAL DENIAL
Family rupture	Very common	Withdrawal of family, marriage prospects, and inheritance in practice	“Islam forbids compulsion in religion.”

— The strongest objection, answered

The objection. You do not understand madhhab diversity, so any specific practice you name is one school's position at most.

What is true in it. Correct, and this codex uses that diversity as evidence rather than ignoring it – the Hanafi position on a woman contracting her own marriage is cited precisely because it shows the restrictive position is contested rather than divine.

The answer. But diversity cannot function as a permanent alibi. If a practice occurs, someone is enforcing it, and the question of who pays the enforcing scholar has a public answer in most of these countries.

SECTION 04

What healthy looks like here

~87–90% of Muslims; authority located in the Qur'an, Sunnah, scholarly consensus, and four major legal schools; no single head.

- Independent scholars maintaining the classical tradition of distance from rulers; communities funding mosques locally to avoid strings-attached foreign money; internal debate cultures where madhhab disagreement models legitimate pluralism.
- Indonesia's Nahdlatul Ulama and Muhammadiyah – mass-membership organizations with genuinely contested leadership elections, together representing well over a hundred million people – show that accountable Sunni institutions exist at scale.

SOURCES FOR THIS SECTION: 17 18

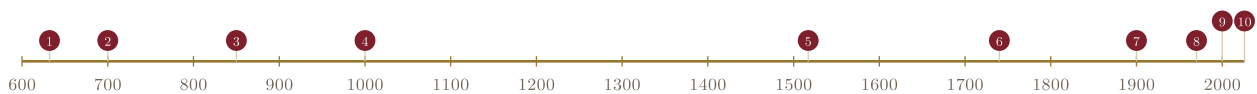
SECTION 05

History

Emerged from the majority position in early succession disputes; classical institutions (madrasas, madhhabs, caliphal patronage) built durable scholarly authority; the modern era added state religious ministries, Gulf-funded missionary networks, and satellite/online preachers.

— Timeline

History at a glance



NUMBERED MARKERS MATCH THE TIMELINE BELOW; SPACING IS PROPORTIONAL TO THE YEARS.

- 1 **632–661 CE**
Succession settled by community consensus rather than lineage
The defining Sunni position: legitimate authority is communal, not hereditary-charismatic.
- 2 **700–950**
Four legal schools form around founders active c. 700–855 (Hanafi, Maliki, Shafi'i, Hanbali) and consolidate over the following century
Interpretation becomes a professional discipline with credentials and precedent.
- 3 **850–1100**
Canonical hadith collections compiled (al-Bukhari, Muslim); theology (kalam) debates; Sufi mysticism spreads — organized Sufi orders (tariqas) follow in the 12th–13th centuries
Authority is textual, and therefore belongs to whoever controls training.
- 4 **1000–1500**
Madrasa systems and waqf funding expand across the Islamic world
Scholarly independence rests on endowment income — until states control the endowments.
- 5 **1517–1924**
Ottoman state appoints a religious hierarchy under the Shaykh al-Islam
Scholars become salaried officials; endorsement becomes a job requirement.
- 6 **1740S–1800S**
Wahhabi movement allies with the House of Saud
A purist reform movement acquires a state — and later, oil.
- 7 **1900S**
Colonial dismantling of waqf and sharia courts; Muslim Brotherhood founded 1928
Mass-movement Islamism emerges as a modern political form.
- 8 **1970S–2000S**
Petro-funded global mosque, school, and publishing networks
One interpretation gains disproportionate global distribution capacity. ACADEMIC SOURCE

9

2000S–PRESENT

Satellite and internet preachers; state crackdowns on independent clerics
Authority fragments online while states tighten control of the pulpit.

10

PRESENT

Reform and feminist scholarship; official establishments closely aligned with governments
The classical check on rulers is largely gone; the recovery effort is underway from the margins.

— Moments in the room

833–848 — THE INQUISITION THAT FAILED

The Abbasid caliph al-Ma'mun imposed a doctrinal test on scholars. Ahmad ibn Hanbal refused, was imprisoned and flogged, and did not recant. The policy was abandoned; his refusal became foundational.

Why it matters. The tradition's own founding precedent for scholarly independence from the state. It is the strongest internal argument against every state-appointed council on this page – and it belongs to the tradition, not to its critics.

1961 — THE UNIVERSITY IS NATIONALISED

Egypt's Law 103 reorganised al-Azhar under state control, converting the Muslim world's most cited seat of learning into an institution whose leadership is appointed under state law. Since 2012 the Grand Imam has been elected by al-Azhar's own Council of Senior Scholars.

Why it matters. The moment the trail from 'who accredits the scholars' to 'a ministry' was formally paved. Before this, the answer was contested; after it, it was administrative.

2016 — A CONFERENCE DECIDES WHO COUNTS

At Grozny, a conference of scholars convened under Chechen state patronage issued a definition of Sunni orthodoxy that excluded certain currents. Rival states and scholars immediately disputed it.

Why it matters. Orthodoxy defined by a conference held under a head of state's patronage – and the dispute that followed ran along state lines rather than theological ones. The map of the argument was political.

SOURCES FOR THIS SECTION: 8 9 48 49

SECTION 06

Branches & variants

Four legal schools; theological currents from Ash'ari and Maturidi to Salafi and Deobandi/Barelvi; Sufi orders overlay all of them.

BRANCH OR CURRENT	WHERE IT PREDOMINATES	WHAT DIFFERS ON THIS PAGE'S QUESTIONS
Hanafi school (Abu Hanifa, c. 700–767)	Turkey, Central Asia, Pakistan, India ⁴⁷	The school that lets an adult woman contract her own marriage – the reason this page treats guardianship as contested, not divine ⁴⁷ .
Maliki school (Malik ibn Anas, d. 795)	North, West and Central Africa ⁵⁴	Reads the sources through the practice ('amal) of the Medina community ⁵⁴ .
Shafi'i school (al-Shafi'i, 767–820)	East Africa, parts of Arabia, Indonesia, the Kurds ⁵⁵	The predominant school where this page's Indonesian and Malaysian court records come from: child-marriage dispensations and apostasy jurisdiction ^{4 5 31} .
Hanbali school (Ahmad ibn Hanbal, 780–855)	Saudi Arabia ⁵⁶	The textualist school; its founder's refusal of the caliph's test (833–848) is the tradition's founding precedent for scholarly independence ⁴⁹ .
Salafi and Wahhabi currents	Arabian origin, spread globally through Gulf-funded institutions (see Money)	Put direct reading of the texts ahead of the four schools' accumulated rulings; the 1744 Saudi-Wahhabi pact joined the current to a state ⁵⁷ .
Deobandi and Barelvi movements	South Asia and its diaspora; Deoband founded 1867 ⁵⁸	Rival South Asian seminary networks whose disputes have at times turned violent ^{58 59} .
Sufi orders	Everywhere; strongest in Africa, the Balkans, South and Southeast Asia	Authority through a living shaykh; the 2016 Grozny conference defined orthodoxy to include Sufism and exclude Salafism ⁴⁸ .
Mass organizations	Indonesia: Nahdlatul Ulama (~57% identify) and Muhammadiyah (~6%) ¹⁸	Hold contested internal elections – the counterexample to state-appointed authority ¹⁷ .

SECTION 07

Structure

— Size and shape

Adherents	About 1.7–1.8 billion (roughly 87–90% of Muslims). ACADEMIC SOURCE · Pew
Regions	Indonesia, Pakistan, India, Bangladesh, Egypt, Nigeria, Turkey, Malaysia, Morocco, Saudi Arabia, Central Asia.
Trend	Growing with population; Salafi-influenced practice has expanded well beyond its original geography via funded institutions and media.
Participation	Ranges from state-enforced to nominal. Mosque attendance is gendered – male attendance is what most surveys actually measure.

— Authority

- Scholars and muftis issue fatwas; state grand muftis serve governments; transnational movements (Salafi networks, Deobandi and Barelvi institutions, the Muslim Brotherhood tradition) compete for interpretive market share.
- Gulf petro-funding built a global infrastructure of mosques, schools, and translated literature exporting particular interpretations. [ACADEMIC SOURCE / INVESTIGATIVE REPORT](#)

— The top of the chain

The scholarly class defines orthodoxy; states appoint the scholarly class. Hold both sentences at once.

OFFICE	WHO SITS IN IT NOW	CHOSEN BY	REMOVABLE BY
al-Azhar (Cairo) – the tradition's most cited seat of learning	Grand Imam Ahmed el-Tayeb, appointed by the president in 2010	The Council of Senior Scholars (since 2012)	Nobody – the 2014 Constitution makes the office irremovable
Saudi Council of Senior Scholars	Chaired by the Grand Mufti – Saleh al-Fawzan since 2025; every member sits by royal appointment	Royal decree	Royal decree
Turkey's Diyanet	Safi Arpaguş, appointed by presidential decree in September 2025; the Diyanet drafts the Friday sermon read in some 90,000 mosques	The Turkish presidency	The Turkish presidency

THE TELL

Ask who accredits the scholars who decide who counts as a scholar. The trail ends at a ministry almost every time – al-Azhar, made irremovable by Egypt's 2014 constitution, is the partial exception, and its budget is still a state line.

— Who holds what

ENTITY	TYPE	HOLDER	HOLDS	WHY IT MATTERS TO YOU	RECEIPT
Official grand mufti offices	State clerical establishment	State-appointed muftis	Fatwa authority that tracks government policy	Whether a ruling you follow is religion or foreign policy	GOVERNMENT REPORT
Al-Azhar and comparable state-linked institutions	Scholarly authority	Grand Imam and senior council	Global interpretive prestige, funded and appointed within a state relationship	What counts as orthodox, decided inside a state's structure	ACADEMIC SOURCE
Transnational madrasa networks	Education	Network leaderships and funders	Free schooling for the poor and a lifetime pipeline of dependent graduates	Whether a boy from a poor family can ever earn outside religion	ACADEMIC SOURCE
Gulf religious foundations	Funding	State and royal charitable bodies	Decades of exported mosque, school, and publishing infrastructure	The books in your local mosque's library	ACADEMIC SOURCE
Satellite and platform preachers	Media	Individual celebrity scholars and their companies	Audiences larger than any classical scholar ever had, with no ijaza required	Who your teenager takes their religion from	PATTERN OBSERVED
Majelis Ulama Indonesia (MUI)	Semi-official scholarly council	Council leadership drawn from the major Islamic organizations, state-funded	Nationally influential fatwas – including a 2005 fatwa declaring Ahmadiyya outside Islam and ruling against pluralism and liberalism – and a continuing role in halal certification	Whether a minority mosque in your district is tolerated, and who certifies your food	OFFICIAL POLICY / ACADEMIC SOURCE

SOURCES FOR THIS SECTION: [6](#) [7](#) [8](#) [9](#) [10](#) [11](#) [12](#) [15](#) [16](#)

SECTION 08

Law & state here

Sunni Islam has no single legal regime: the state does. This table sets the seven jurisdictions on this page side by side.

COUNTRY	LEAVING ISLAM	CRITICIZING ISLAM	WHO CONTROLS THE PULPIT AND THE FATWA
Saudi Arabia	Punishable by death under the kingdom's application of Islamic law ⁵⁰	Prosecuted; clerics who declined state positions detained since 2017 ^{13 51}	Grand Mufti and Council of Senior Scholars, by royal order ¹⁰
United Arab Emirates	Hudud crimes – the basis for a death sentence for apostasy – were removed from the penal code in 2020 ²⁰ ; still listed as a risk by human-rights monitors ⁵⁰	A crime: at least one year for publicly offending Islam's sacred beliefs or rites (Art. 312) ^{19 20}	Awqaf writes one Friday sermon for every mosque ²⁴ ; the UAE Council for Fatwa is the official fatwa authority ²¹
Egypt	Not a crime in the penal code, but courts have dissolved a marriage on apostasy grounds ²⁷	Up to five years for "contempt of religion" (Art. 98(f)), actively prosecuted ²⁶	al-Azhar's Grand Imam, irremovable since 2014 ^{8 9}
Turkey	No penalty	Six months to a year for publicly insulting religious values (Art. 216(3)), used against critics ⁶¹	The Diyanet, a state presidency, drafts the sermon for some 90,000 mosques ^{11 12}
Pakistan	Not codified; listed among countries where expressing apostasy can bring a death sentence ⁵⁰	Mandatory death sentence for defiling the Prophet's name (s. 295-C) ²⁸	Federal and provincial religious bodies; no single mufti
Indonesia	Not a crime; publicly inciting others to have no religion carries up to 2 years (new Criminal Code, in force 2 January 2026) ³⁰	Up to 3 years (Art. 300) ³⁰ ; a sitting governor was jailed for blasphemy in 2017 ²⁹	MUI issues fatwas; the state now runs halal certification ^{6 7}
Malaysia	For state syariah courts; civil courts decline jurisdiction (Lina Joy, 2007) ³¹	Offences under state syariah enactments	State religious councils and muftis

The UAE's new Personal Status Law (in force 15 April 2025) is the region's most significant recent change: marriage at 18 for both sexes, a court may marry an adult woman over her guardian's objection, maternal custody to 18, and judges may apply general sharia principles without being bound to one school ^{22 23}.

— Who can compel an answer

Charity regulators over mosque trusts and endowments; education authorities over supplementary schools; civil courts. For the great state-appointed councils, accountability runs through the appointing state – asking the council to answer is asking the ministry.

SECTION 09

Money

— Where it comes from

- Same base flows as Islam generally; plus state salaries for clerics, Gulf endowments for institutions abroad, and celebrity-preacher media economies.
- Madrasa networks in South Asia run on donations and offer free education – genuine service that also creates pipeline loyalty. [ACADEMIC SOURCE](#)

— Follow the money

FLOW	STATED PURPOSE	HOW IT CONTROLS	WHO BENEFITS
Mosque donations and building funds	Community worship space	Major donors gain informal veto over imams and sermon content	Boards, donors, and their preferred interpretation
Madrasa funding (domestic and foreign)	Free religious education	Free schooling for the poor creates loyalty pipelines and dependency	Institutions, sponsoring states ACADEMIC SOURCE
State clerical salaries	Public religious services	Salaried clergy cannot criticize the paymaster	Governments purchasing legitimacy OFFICIAL POLICY
Preacher media economies	Dawah and teaching	Piety monetized through channels, tours, and merchandise with no accountability structure	Celebrity preachers, media companies

— Pipelines this tradition shares

ZAKAT TO PATRONAGE

Source. Obligatory alms at a fixed rate

Path. State zakat board → Appointed distributors → Recipients and political constituencies

Disclosed. Collection totals

Hidden. Distribution criteria and discretionary awards

CERTIFICATION FEE

Source. Ordinary commerce seeking religious compliance

Path. Certifying agency → Scholarly or rabbinic supervisors → Advisory positions at certified firms

Disclosed. Certification status

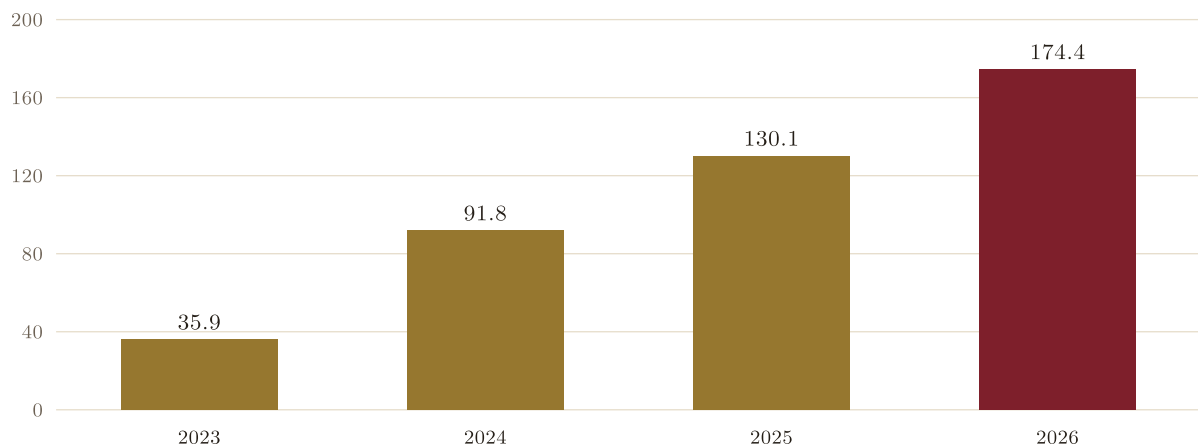
Hidden. Fee schedules and advisory compensation

PILGRIMAGE ECONOMY**Source.** A religious obligation with a fixed destination**Path.** Licensed operators → Host state revenue → Concession holders**Disclosed.** Visa quotas and pricing**Hidden.** Margins and concession awards**STATE CLERICAL PAYROLL****Source.** Public revenue**Path.** Religious affairs ministry → Licensed clergy → Sermon content approval**Disclosed.** Headcount and budget**Hidden.** Content directives**HONOR AND MARRIAGE ECONOMY****Source.** Families managing reputation**Path.** Matchmakers and community brokers → School admission and business trust → Conformity across the whole family**Disclosed.** Nothing**Hidden.** Everything, because none of it is written

— Money in numbers

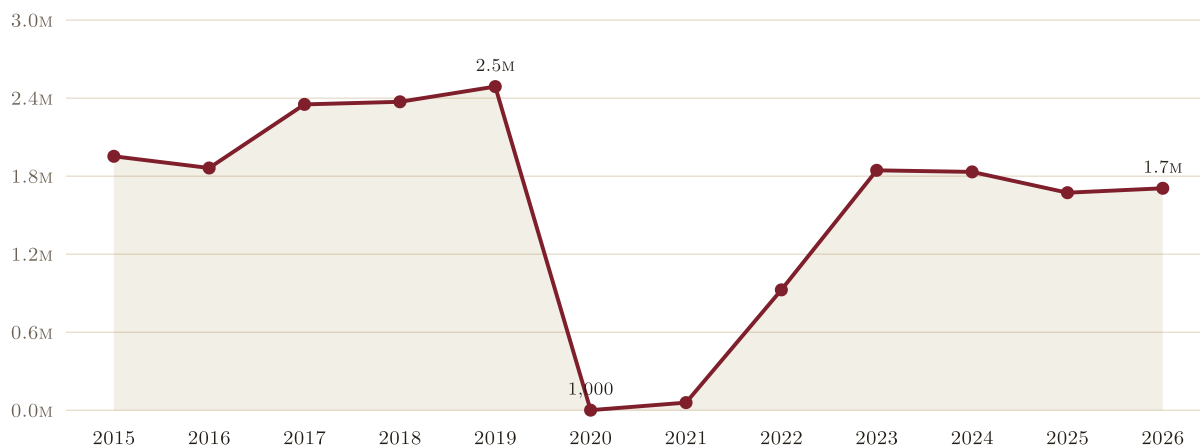
Most Sunni money is never published: zakat to individuals, sadaqa, madrasa fees, and foreign institutional funding have no public ledger. Two state-run flows do publish numbers.

Turkey's Diyanet: central-budget allocation



BILLION LIRA (NOMINAL) — NOMINAL LIRA DURING YEARS OF HIGH INFLATION; THE RISE IS REAL BUT SMALLER IN CONSTANT TERMS. 34 35 32 33

Hajj pilgrims, 2015–2026



PILGRIMS — QUOTAS, FEES AND VISAS FOR THE PILGRIMAGE EVERY ABLE MUSLIM OWES ONCE ARE SET BY ONE STATE.
36

- **Diyanet:** £35.9bn (2023) → £91.8bn (2024) → £130.1bn (2025) → £174.4bn (2026) ^{32 33 34 35}.
- **Hajj:** 2,489,406 pilgrims in 2019; 1,000 in 2020; 1,673,230 in 2025; 1,707,301 in 2026 ³⁶.

SECTION 10

Genealogy

SCHOLARLY AUTHORITY ABSORBED INTO STATE PAYROLL

Origin. Ottoman appointment of a religious hierarchy under the Shaykh al-Islam; completed by colonial and post-colonial religious affairs ministries. [ACADEMIC SOURCE](#)

What it was for. Classical madhhab scholarship was independent because waqf endowments paid for it, not rulers. That independence let scholars rebuke kings – a genuine constitutional check.

Why that reason expired. Colonial states seized the endowments and modern states replaced them with salaries. The check is gone, and nothing replaced it.

Who benefits now. Governments, which obtain religious endorsement for policy at the price of a civil-service wage. The loss is yours: there is now no institution that can tell a ruler he is wrong.

FREE MADRASA EDUCATION AS LOYALTY PIPELINE

Origin. Medieval madrasas funded by waqf, providing genuine mass education centuries before public schooling existed. [ACADEMIC SOURCE](#)

What it was for. Real charity in a world with no alternative. Poor children learned to read.

Why that reason expired. Where hifz-only curricula displace literacy, numeracy, and employable skills, the charity becomes a trap: a graduate whose only credential is religious is economically dependent on religious institutions for life.

Who benefits now. Sponsoring states and movements that acquire a generation with no exit options. And the institutions staffed by graduates who cannot work anywhere else.

GUARDIANSHIP OVER WOMEN'S MARRIAGE

Origin. Classical requirement of a wali for the bride, in societies where women had no legal standing. [ACADEMIC SOURCE](#)

What it was for. A woman without contractual capacity needed a representative who was liable for the arrangement.

Why that reason expired. She now has contractual capacity in every field but this one. The Hanafi school itself permits an adult woman to contract her own marriage, which demonstrates the requirement was always contested, not divine consensus.

Who benefits now. Fathers and brothers, who retain veto power over an adult woman's life. And the honor economy that makes her choices a family asset.

'HONOR' ENFORCEMENT OUTSOURCED TO FAMILY

Origin. Pre-Islamic tribal honor codes that survived Islamization and later acquired religious vocabulary. [ACADEMIC SOURCE](#)

What it was for. Kin-group survival in stateless environments where a family's reputation was its only security.

Why that reason expired. There are states, police, and courts. What remains is violence against women defended in religious language by people who cannot cite a text for it.

Who benefits now. Male relatives, and every institution that gets free enforcement while truthfully insisting it never ordered anything. This is the purest example of cultural outsourcing in the codex.

SECTION 11

Reach

— Information

- Official 'grand mufti' offices issue fatwas that track government policy closely; independent scholars who diverge face suspension, travel bans, or prosecution. GOVERNMENT REPORT
- Approved-scholar lists and 'don't take your religion from the internet' warnings function as source control, however reasonable the surface concern. PATTERN OBSERVED
- Diaspora communities may treat academic Islamic studies as inherently hostile, closing the only avenue for internal historical critique. PATTERN OBSERVED

— Children

- Maktab/madrasa instruction from early childhood; in some systems, full-time hifz displaces literacy, numeracy, and employable skills. ACADEMIC SOURCE
- Documented physical abuse and, in some residential madrasas, sexual abuse with weak reporting pathways. INVESTIGATIVE REPORT
- Gender segregation and modesty enforcement begin young; girls' schooling is curtailed in specific contexts (extreme case: Taliban bans). GOVERNMENT REPORT

— Bodies

- Male-only imamate for mixed congregations; women's prayer space often smaller, partitioned, or absent — physical architecture as hierarchy. PATTERN OBSERVED
- Marriage requires a male guardian's involvement for the bride in most schools; polygyny permitted for men.
- Forced and child marriage occur where religious marriage operates outside civil registration; the religious form is used to bypass state minimums. GOVERNMENT REPORT
- Domestic-violence verses and hadith are contested internally; conservative readings have been used to counsel women to endure. ACADEMIC SOURCE / FORMER MEMBER TESTIMONY

SOURCES FOR THIS SECTION: 13 14

SECTION 12

The 30 techniques

Thirty named techniques from domestic-abuse and social-psychology research, applied to institutions, in the eight stages of the cycle. Each carries an evidence grade for this tradition.

How the 30 techniques are established here

11

15

4

TAUGHT 11

CULTURAL 15

CONTESTED 4

— All thirty at a glance

1	Love Bombing	CULTURAL	23	2	Weaponized Generosity	CULTURAL	23
3	Future Faking	CULTURAL	24	4	Hoovering	CULTURAL	25
5	Devaluation	TAUGHT	25	6	Gaslighting	TAUGHT	26
7	Double Bind	TAUGHT	26	8	Intermittent Reinforcement	CULTURAL	27
9	Moving the Goalposts	CULTURAL	28	10	Strategic Ambiguity	CULTURAL	28
11	Projection	CULTURAL	29	12	DARVO	CULTURAL	29
13	Normalization / Desensitization	CULTURAL	30	14	Isolation	CONTESTED	30
15	Triangulation	CONTESTED	31	16	Flying Monkeys	TAUGHT	32
17	Smear Campaign	TAUGHT	32	18	Silent Treatment / Stonewalling	TAUGHT	33
19	Manufactured Consent	TAUGHT	33	20	Trauma Bonding	TAUGHT	34
21	Learned Helplessness	CONTESTED	34	22	Benevolent Control	CONTESTED	35
23	Infantilization	TAUGHT	35	24	Identity Erosion	TAUGHT	36
25	Spiritual Bypassing	TAUGHT	36	26	Financial Control	CULTURAL	37
27	Manufactured Crisis	CULTURAL	37	28	Discard	CULTURAL	38
29	Replacement	CULTURAL	38	30	Plausible Deniability	CULTURAL	39

— Stage 1 · Idealize

You arrive with a need and are met with more warmth than you have had in years.

A convert or returnee is celebrated intensely – meals, mentorship, a place, a purpose, proof that the method works.

What it asks of you: Were you welcomed, or were you scored?

1 · Love Bombing

Overwhelming affection on arrival to create emotional dependency before terms are revealed.

How it shows here

- A convert is often quickly taught the “correct” prayer, “correct” creed, “correct” scholars, “correct” gender boundaries, and “correct” method – frequently before they understand the internal diversity of Islam.
- Salafi or conservative Sunni environments may greet the convert warmly, then immediately begin stripping away music, mixed friendships, holidays, clothing choices, dating habits, and independent interpretation.
- The person is celebrated as a trophy of dawah: proof that Islam is spreading, proof that the community is righteous, proof that the method works.

The strongest defense. Teaching correct practice is necessary. Islam is not whatever the convert wants it to be.

The counter. Instruction is not the problem. The problem is speed plus dependency. When affection is front-loaded and correction follows immediately after attachment forms, the convert learns that love is available only through obedience.

Evidence grade. CULTURAL Convert celebration and mentorship are community practice with no governing body.

2 · Weaponized Generosity

Giving help that installs unspoken obligation.

How it shows here

- Sunni communities may provide strong social infrastructure: mosque meals, Qur’an classes, rent help, funeral support, marriage networks, youth programs, and convert mentorship.
- Conservative environments may give practical help first, then attach it to “proper” practice: correct prayer, correct creed, correct scholars, correct dress, correct gender boundaries.
- A convert who receives community support may later be told that disagreement with the dominant interpretation shows arrogance, Western corruption, weak iman, or disrespect for the Prophet.

- Family and mosque aid can become inseparable: help with housing, jobs, marriage, or childcare may be tied to visible conformity.

The strongest defense. Teaching correct Islam is part of caring for someone. A convert needs guidance.

The counter. Guidance becomes control when the guide also controls the food, friends, marriage prospects, and social belonging. If material and emotional support are used to accelerate conformity before the person understands Sunni diversity, then help is functioning as capture.

Evidence grade. CULTURAL Convert celebration and mentorship are community practice with no governing body.

— Stage 2 · Hook

You are given a future that cannot be verified, and a rope for whenever you drift toward the door.

Paradise and the pleasure of Allah, deliverable after death. And a retrieval network of relatives, matchmakers, and community elders who begin calling the moment your attendance drops.

What it asks of you: The people retrieving you are not employees. They are family, which is exactly why the mechanism costs the institution nothing.

3 · Future Faking

Promising a future that keeps you invested but never has to arrive.

How it shows here

- Sunni institutions often frame salvation around correct creed, correct prayer, correct practice, correct scholars, correct law, correct community, and correct avoidance of innovation.
- The future promise is safety: stay with the saved group, follow the Sunnah, obey qualified scholars, avoid deviance, and you will be among those successful in the Hereafter.
- In stricter environments, the believer is told that tiny details may carry eternal significance: how you pray, dress, speak, eat, marry, celebrate, vote, shave, raise children, or interpret texts.
- The future keeps expanding into regulation. It is not enough to be Muslim. You must be the right kind of Muslim, under the right authorities, avoiding the wrong books, wrong sects, wrong friendships, wrong innovations.

The strongest defense. Sunni guidance preserves the Prophet's way and protects believers from misguidance.

The counter. Protection becomes future faking when salvation anxiety is used to keep people dependent on gatekeepers. If every ordinary decision is loaded with afterlife consequence, the believer never matures. The scholar becomes the map, the mosque becomes the checkpoint, and paradise remains the reward for staying inside the approved lane.

Evidence grade. CULTURAL Retrieval is carried out by relatives and matchmakers, which is why no institution can be held to it.

4 · Hoovering

Pulling someone back after they've started to leave, through guilt, love, or fear.

How it shows here

- Someone leaving a Sunni community may be told to return to the Qur'an and Sunnah, stop following desires, avoid corrupt influences, and speak to a proper scholar.
- Conservative communities may frame doubts as ignorance, arrogance, Western brainwashing, liberal corruption, or influence from deviant sects.
- The person may be urged to attend halaqas, meet the imam, resume prayer, wear proper dress, leave "bad company," and re-enter the rhythm of the mosque.
- The hoover is often routed through religious correction: "You don't need to leave Islam. You just need proper knowledge."
- Family may push marriage, mosque attendance, or scholar consultation as a way to "stabilize" the doubter.

The strongest defense. Seeking knowledge and consulting scholars are normal parts of Sunni Islam.

The counter. Guidance is not neutral when the approved guides all lead back to the same conclusion. If every doubt must be processed through authorities whose job is to preserve your obedience, then "ask a scholar" means "return to the frame that made leaving impossible."

Evidence grade. CULTURAL Retrieval is carried out by relatives and matchmakers, which is why no institution can be held to it.

— Stage 3 · Devalue

You are taught that you are broken, that your perception is unreliable, and that both exits from the trap lead back inside.

Someone stricter is always the benchmark. Your practice is a bit lax, your creed a bit loose, your iman a bit weak — never stated harshly, always present.

What it asks of you: You are being measured against a standard that recedes as you approach it.

5 · Devaluation

Reducing your sense of worth so you become dependent on the institution for identity.

How it shows here

- Sunni environments can devalue by teaching that the ordinary believer is not equipped to interpret religion independently and must rely on scholars, madhhabs, hadith authorities, fatwas, and

approved teachers.

- The believer is told that sincerity is not enough; they must have correct aqidah, correct fiqh, correct prayer, correct intention, correct dress, correct gender conduct, correct avoidance of bid'ah.
- A person whose questions may be accused of following desires, lacking knowledge, being arrogant, imitating the West, or disrespecting the Prophet.
- The self is made small before an enormous apparatus of correctness. The believer is never simply faithful; they are always at risk of error.
- Fear of misguidance keeps the person dependent on those who claim to know the safe path.

The strongest defense. Sunni scholarship protects people from ignorance and misinterpretation.

The counter. Protection becomes devaluation when it teaches adults that their conscience is dangerous unless filtered through approved authorities. If every independent moral alarm is dismissed as ignorance or desire, then scholarship has become a leash.

Evidence grade. TAUGHT Deference to scholarly authority over personal judgment is taught in most institutional settings and disputed in others.

6 · Gaslighting

Making you doubt your own experience so you trust the institution's interpretation instead.

How it shows here

- A believer asks about conflicting hadith, harsh legal rulings, gender inequality, sectarian claims, or historical problems, and is told, “Ask people of knowledge,” but only approved scholars count.
- If the answer does not satisfy them, the problem becomes their adab, arrogance, lack of Arabic, weak iman, or contamination by Orientalists.
- A person’s conscience may say a ruling is unjust, but the system says, “Allah knows better, and scholars know more than you.”
- In stricter environments, doubt itself becomes suspicious: sincere questions are allowed only if they end in submission.

The strongest defense. Religious law is complex; laypeople need qualified scholarship.

The counter. Expertise is not gaslighting by itself. It becomes gaslighting when expertise is used to override conscience without accountability. If every moral objection is dismissed because you are not qualified, then scholarship has become a wall, not a light.

Evidence grade. TAUGHT Deference to scholarly authority over personal judgment is taught in most institutional settings and disputed in others.

7 · Double Bind

A trap where both options lead to compliance. No exit serves you.

How it shows here

- Sunni students are told to follow qualified scholars, not their own whims – and when scholars disagree, choosing between them is itself called 'fatwa shopping' or following desire. You must not interpret alone, and you must not choose among interpreters.
- Young Muslims are told marriage completes half the religion and delay is dangerous – while also told obedience to parents is paramount, even when parents block or force a match.
- Criticizing a celebrated shaykh is backbiting; staying silent about his documented harm is loyalty. The victim's speech is the only sin with a name.

The strongest defense. Deference to scholarship protects the religion from chaos and self-serving interpretation.

The counter. Protection from chaos does not require a system where the layperson is wrong whichever way they turn. When every path except passive deference has a disqualifying label, scholarship has become gatekeeping.

Evidence grade. TAUGHT Deference to scholarly authority over personal judgment is taught in most institutional settings and disputed in others.

— Stage 4 · Confuse

The rewards become unpredictable, the standard keeps moving, the answers stop meaning anything, and the accusation gets turned around.

Object and you are arrogant, Western-influenced, disrespecting scholars, or serving Islamophobes. The accusation is about your character, never the substance you raised.

What it asks of you: When 'who do you think you are' replaces an answer, you have your answer.

8 · Intermittent Reinforcement

Unpredictable reward that creates addictive emotional dependency.

How it shows here

- Students of a shaykh receive attention in unannounced portions – ijazah, front-row nearness, a public du'a – and the competition for unpredictable favor disciplines a whole student body without a single command.
- Communities alternately celebrate the convert (Eid invitations, marriage interest) and forget him (unreturned messages, no one notices his absence) – and he intensifies practice to re-trigger the welcome that came free the first week.
- Strictness itself pays out intermittently: most days cost comfort with no visible return, then a dream, an answered du'a, a scholar's nod – one coin that funds another year at the machine.

The strongest defense. Scholars cannot mentor everyone equally; proximity naturally follows effort and adab.

The counter. Naturally unequal attention becomes a control instrument the moment it is the community's main currency and its rules are unstated. If effort truly earned nearness, the schedule would be learnable. It is kept unlearnable because unlearnable is what compels.

Evidence grade. CULTURAL Accusations of arrogance and Westernization are social sanctions, not rulings, and carry no procedure or appeal.

9 · Moving the Goalposts

The standard of success keeps shifting so you can never arrive.

How it shows here

- A believer is told to follow the Qur'an and Sunnah. Then they must follow the correct madhhab, correct aqidah, correct scholars, correct hadith interpretation, correct dress, correct gender rules, and correct avoidance of bid'ah.
- A person asks a scholar and follows the answer. Later they are told they asked the wrong scholar, followed a weak opinion, lacked adab, or misunderstood the ruling.
- Reformist or questioning Muslims are first told to seek knowledge. When they gain knowledge and still disagree, the standard moves to Arabic mastery, ijazah, classical training, or deference to tradition.

The strongest defense. Religious knowledge has levels; laypeople need qualified guidance.

The counter. Levels become a trap when qualification is defined so narrowly that disagreement is impossible. If no amount of study grants permission to dissent, "knowledge" is just a locked gate.

Evidence grade. CULTURAL Accusations of arrogance and Westernization are social sanctions, not rulings, and carry no procedure or appeal.

10 · Strategic Ambiguity

Language that sounds profound but means nothing specific – functioning as a shutdown to real questions.

How it shows here

- "Follow the scholars" sounds clear, but which scholars count often shifts depending on the desired answer.
- Bid'ah, modesty, proper aqidah, and correct adab can remain vague enough to discipline dissent without transparent boundaries.
- Communities say Islam is easy, then impose dense requirements around prayer details, dress, gender, sectarian boundaries, and speech.

The strongest defense. Sunni jurisprudence contains legitimate diversity and scholarly disagreement.

The counter. Diversity becomes strategic ambiguity when pluralism is invoked to soften criticism but narrowness is enforced on members. If options exist only when defending the system, not when freeing the believer, ambiguity is doing control work.

Evidence grade. CULTURAL Accusations of arrogance and Westernization are social sanctions, not rulings, and carry no procedure or appeal.

11 · Projection

Accusing the outside world of the exact thing the institution practices.

How it shows here

- Sunni gatekeepers may accuse questioners of following desires while protecting their own desire for authority, certainty, male control, and communal conformity.
- A believer who asks about harsh rulings may be told they lack knowledge, while scholars avoid admitting interpretive disagreement or political influence.
- Reformers may be accused of innovation while conservative institutions use modern fundraising, media, branding, and political machinery.
- Doubters are accused of Western influence while communities ignore the influence of patriarchy, nationalism, tribalism, or authoritarian culture.

The strongest defense. Sunni scholarship protects people from making religion up according to personal desire.

The counter. Scholarship becomes projection when every challenge is called desire but the institution never examines its own desires: control, reputation, uniformity, and immunity from scrutiny.

Evidence grade. CULTURAL Accusations of arrogance and Westernization are social sanctions, not rulings, and carry no procedure or appeal.

12 · DARVO

Deny the wrongdoing. Attack the person who raised it. Reverse victim and offender.

How it shows here

- A person questions a scholar, imam, or institution over gender rules, abuse handling, financial misuse, or authoritarian control. The first response is denial: “You misunderstood the ruling,” “That is culture, not Islam,” or “The scholar did nothing wrong.”
- Then comes attack: “You lack adab,” “You follow desires,” “You are influenced by the West,” “You are spreading fitna.”
- Then reversal: the scholar or mosque becomes the victim of slander, while the harmed person becomes a danger to community unity.
- Women challenging male authority may be accused of feminism, rebellion, immodesty, or trying to corrupt Muslim families.
- Dissent is treated as a spiritual threat greater than the original abuse.

The strongest defense. Islam requires evidence, due process, and protection from slander.

The counter. Due process is not DARVO. But if “bring evidence” is demanded from victims while leaders control the evidence, witnesses, reputation, and religious framing, then due process has become a locked courtroom where the accused owns the judge.

Evidence grade. CULTURAL Accusations of arrogance and Westernization are social sanctions, not rulings, and carry no procedure or appeal.

13 · Normalization / Desensitization

Practices that would seem extreme to an outsider feel normal to insiders because they were installed before critical evaluation developed.

How it shows here

- Conservative Sunni environments can normalize constant correction: prayer posture, beard length, hijab standards, gender interaction, speech, music, celebrations, and “proper” aqidah.
- Believers may become desensitized to scholar dependency: if unsure, ask; if troubled, ask; if morally alarmed, ask; if the answer still feels wrong, your nafs or ignorance is the problem.
- Warnings against bid‘ah, deviant sects, liberal Muslims, ex-Muslims, and Western influence can make intellectual narrowing feel like protection.
- Women and youth may gradually accept surveillance by family, mosque, and community as ordinary religious concern.

The strongest defense. Sunni practice preserves the Prophet’s example through careful guidance.

The counter. Careful guidance becomes desensitization when correction never ends and autonomy never arrives. If the believer grows used to being watched, corrected, and redirected in every detail, the Sunnah has been turned into a surveillance habit.

Evidence grade. CULTURAL Accusations of arrogance and Westernization are social sanctions, not rulings, and carry no procedure or appeal.

— Stage 5 · Isolate

Your world narrows until every voice you hear is inside the system, and everything you came for now runs through a middleman.

Approved scholars, approved reading, warnings against the internet and academia. Marriage prospects and business trust run through the same network as your religious instruction.

What it asks of you: There is nowhere neutral to take a question. Notice that this was constructed, not inevitable.

14 · Isolation

Shrinking your world until the only voices you hear are inside the system.

How it shows here

- Sunni isolation can happen through approved-scholar ecosystems: listen to these shaykhs, follow this madhhab, avoid deviant sects, avoid liberal Muslims, avoid Shia, avoid ex-Muslims, avoid

secular critics.

- A believer may be told that independent research is dangerous because they lack Arabic, hadith training, fiqh knowledge, or proper adab.
- Conservative Sunni communities may isolate through gender codes, dress expectations, mosque-centered life, marriage pressure, and suspicion of “Western” psychology, feminism, or secular education.
- The person is not always physically cut off; instead, their epistemic world is narrowed. Only certain scholars are safe. Only certain questions are sincere. Only certain conclusions are Islamic.

The strongest defense. Sunni tradition relies on qualified scholarship because religion is complex.

The counter. Expertise becomes isolation when it blocks access to competing interpretations. If the ordinary believer can only consult scholars already approved by the community, then “qualified knowledge” becomes a gated enclosure.

Evidence grade. CONTESTED Approved-scholar lists and warnings against outside sources are movement-specific; the madhhab tradition itself cuts the other way.

15 · Triangulation

Inserting intermediaries between you and the thing you came for, so the institution is always in the middle.

How it shows here

- Sunni communities triangulate through scholars, madhhabs, hadith collections, fatwa sites, imams, parents, and approved teachers.
- A person with moral doubts is told, “Ask people of knowledge,” but only certain scholars count. If they consult reformist or critical voices, they are accused of following desires.
- The believer is compared to the “saved sect,” the pious predecessors, righteous scholars, modest sisters, obedient brothers, and those who “hold firmly to the Sunnah.”
- Triangulation happens through sectarian fear: “Do not listen to Shia,” “Do not listen to liberals,” “Do not listen to Orientalists,” “Do not listen to ex-Muslims.”
- Gender conduct is triangulated through the community: one person’s clothing, prayer, friendships, or marriage choices become everyone’s business because they supposedly affect communal morality.

The strongest defense. Sunni Islam relies on scholarship to preserve correct belief and practice.

The counter. Scholarship becomes triangulation when it is used to outnumber conscience. If every authority you are allowed to consult is selected because it will return you to compliance, then you are not being educated. You are being boxed in by credentials.

Evidence grade. CONTESTED Approved-scholar lists and warnings against outside sources are movement-specific; the madhhab tradition itself cuts the other way.

— Stage 6 · Extract

Now the harvest: your labor, your money, your identity, your silence, your children's schooling, your capacity to trust yourself.

Mosque building funds where major donors quietly select the imam. Free madrasa education that leaves a graduate unemployable outside religious work. State-salaried clerics. Your guardian's signature required for an adult woman's marriage. Object and be told you are arrogant and Westernized.

What it asks of you: A child who leaves school at eighteen unable to earn a living outside religious employment has not been educated. He has been retained.

16 · Flying Monkeys

The community enforces the institution's norms without being asked – mobilized by culture, not memos.

How it shows here

- A questioning Sunni Muslim may be told by multiple people to “ask a scholar,” but only approved scholars are acceptable.
- Family, imam, halaqa friends, and online teachers may all converge: “You lack knowledge,” “This is your nafs,” “You are following desires,” “Don’t listen to liberals or ex-Muslims.”
- Women who resist conservative gender expectations may be corrected by men, women, relatives, mosque teachers, and social media preachers.
- A person exploring other Islamic interpretations may be warned by others that they are falling into bid‘ah, deviance, or Western corruption.

The strongest defense. Sunni Islam values seeking knowledge from qualified scholars.

The counter. Seeking knowledge becomes FLYING MONKEY pressure when “qualified” means “guaranteed to return you to obedience.” If every friend, teacher, imam, and relative sends you back to the same approved authorities, scholarship is being used as crowd control.

Evidence grade. TAUGHT Mosque funding influence, madrasa pipelines, and gendered expectation are taught and structural rather than written.

17 · Smear Campaign

Rewriting your character after departure to protect the institution from the implications of your leaving.

How it shows here

- Sunni dissenters may be smeared as followers of desires, liberals, deviants, Orientalist-influenced, ex-Muslim-influenced, ignorant, arrogant, or lacking adab.
- Reformers may be accused of bid‘ah or trying to water down Islam.

- Women challenging gender restrictions may be smeared as Westernized feminists trying to destroy the family.
- Those who question scholars may be framed as disrespectful and unqualified, regardless of their actual evidence.

The strongest defense. Communities must protect correct belief and prevent confusion.

The counter. Protecting belief becomes smear when disagreement is treated as moral corruption. If the institution answers critique by labeling the critic deviant, it is not protecting truth. It is protecting control.

Evidence grade. TAUGHT Mosque funding influence, madrasa pipelines, and gendered expectation are taught and structural rather than written.

18 · Silent Treatment / Stonewalling

Refusing to engage with legitimate questions in order to maintain control.

How it shows here

- A believer asks about harsh rulings, abuse handling, gender inequality, or contradictory scholarly claims and is told to ask qualified scholars, but no answer is ever allowed to settle against the institution.
- Imams may avoid addressing community abuse publicly to prevent scandal.
- Women who report misconduct may be told to bring witnesses, preserve modesty, avoid gossip, and let elders handle it privately.
- Questions about power are absorbed into religious process: “Have adab,” “be patient,” “this is complex,” “do not speak without knowledge.”

The strongest defense. Islam requires evidence, caution, and qualified judgment.

The counter. Caution becomes stonewalling when power controls the evidence, witnesses, forum, and timeline. If every path to justice runs through those invested in avoiding scandal, the process is a maze, not a court.

Evidence grade. TAUGHT Mosque funding influence, madrasa pipelines, and gendered expectation are taught and structural rather than written.

19 · Manufactured Consent

Creating the appearance of choice when the conditions of choice were shaped before you could evaluate them.

How it shows here

- A believer “chooses” a ruling after being told only certain scholars count and disagreement is following desires.
- Women “choose” stricter dress or segregation in communities where nonconformity means gossip, suspicion, or reduced marriageability.

- A young person “chooses” religious marriage expectations after family, imam, and community define alternatives as haram or dishonorable.
- The layperson “consents” to legal authority because they are told they lack knowledge to disagree.

The strongest defense. Following qualified scholarship is responsible religious practice.

The counter. Guidance becomes manufactured consent when the range of acceptable guidance is preselected. If every approved scholar leads back to compliance and every dissenting scholar is labeled deviant, the believer’s choice is staged.

Evidence grade. TAUGHT Mosque funding influence, madrasa pipelines, and gendered expectation are taught and structural rather than written.

20 · Trauma Bonding

The wound and the bandage come from the same hand.

How it shows here

- Conservative Sunni environments may cycle correction and acceptance: wrong prayer, wrong dress, wrong scholars, wrong gender conduct – then praise when the person aligns.
- The believer is warned about bid‘ah, deviance, hell, weak iman, and following desires; relief comes through approved scholars, proper aqidah, and community acceptance.
- A doubter is made anxious about misguidance, then told safety lies in returning to the Sunnah as interpreted by approved authorities.
- Approval is intermittent: affectionate when compliant, corrective when independent.

The strongest defense. Sunni guidance protects people from error and helps them practice correctly.

The counter. Guidance becomes TRAUMA BONDING when correction destabilizes the person and approval restores them. If the community repeatedly creates anxiety about being wrong and then offers itself as the only safe path, dependency is not accidental.

Evidence grade. TAUGHT Mosque funding influence, madrasa pipelines, and gendered expectation are taught and structural rather than written.

21 · Learned Helplessness

Teaching you that your own judgment is unreliable until you stop trusting it entirely.

How it shows here

- A believer seeks answers from scholars, but every unsatisfying answer leads to another scholar, another warning, another accusation of weak knowledge.
- A woman tries to comply with modesty expectations, but the standard keeps tightening.
- A young person tries to discuss doubts and is told they lack adab, Arabic, proper knowledge, or sincerity.
- Eventually they stop asking because asking only proves deficiency.

The strongest defense. Knowledge has levels, and religious questions require humility.

The counter. Humility becomes LEARNED HELPLESSNESS when no amount of learning permits moral agency. If the believer can never become qualified enough to object, scholarship has become a ceiling.

Evidence grade. CONTESTED Deference to scholars over personal judgment varies enormously by school, country, and community, and is actively disputed internally. *(sourced)*

22 · Benevolent Control

Control wrapped in the language of care, so that resisting the control feels like rejecting the love.

How it shows here

- Sunni authority often presents scholar dependency as protection from ignorance and misguidance.
- Communities may restrict which scholars, books, sects, or interpretations are safe.
- Gender separation, dress codes, and marriage restrictions are framed as preserving modesty and preventing fitna.
- A believer who questions may be told they are being cared for by being redirected to “people of knowledge.”

The strongest defense. Ordinary Muslims need qualified scholarship to avoid error.

The counter. Scholarship becomes BENEVOLENT CONTROL when it narrows the believer’s options before they can think. If only approved authorities are safe and all dissent is desire, care has become intellectual containment.

Evidence grade. CONTESTED Guardianship over an adult woman's marriage is required by some schools and expressly not by the Hanafi position – the disagreement is the evidence. *(sourced)*

23 · Infantilization

Positioning the adult believer as permanently childlike and dependent on institutional authority.

How it shows here

- Laypeople may be told they cannot interpret texts, evaluate rulings, or follow conscience without scholars.
- Women may be treated as needing male guardianship, modesty correction, or community oversight.
- Young adults may be pressured into approved marriage paths because they are not trusted with desire.
- Questioners are redirected to authorities rather than engaged as capable adults.

The strongest defense. Religious knowledge is complex and requires qualified scholars.

The counter. Expertise becomes INFANTILIZATION when it denies adult agency. If no amount of study, conscience, or lived experience allows disagreement, scholarship has become parental control.

Evidence grade. TAUGHT Mosque funding influence, madrasa pipelines, and gendered expectation are taught and structural rather than written.

24 · Identity Erosion

Gradually replacing your identity with a role the institution provides, until you can't separate who you are from where you belong.

How it shows here

- Sunni environments may define the person through correct aqidah, correct scholars, correct prayer, correct dress, correct gender conduct, correct avoidance of bid'ah, and correct community.
- The believer's own moral reasoning is reduced beneath scholar dependency.
- Personal conscience becomes suspect if it conflicts with approved fiqh.
- Women and young people may be absorbed into roles defined by modesty, obedience, marriage, and communal reputation.
- A person may stop asking, "Is this just?" and start asking, "Which approved scholar says this is allowed?"

The strongest defense. Sunni scholarship preserves guidance and protects believers from error.

The counter. Guidance becomes IDENTITY EROSION when it replaces conscience instead of forming it. If every meaningful choice must pass through approved authority, the believer's moral self has been outsourced.

Evidence grade. TAUGHT Mosque funding influence, madrasa pipelines, and gendered expectation are taught and structural rather than written.

25 · Spiritual Bypassing

Using spiritual language to avoid engaging with real pain, real questions, and real accountability.

How it shows here

- Legal or gender harm may be bypassed with "Allah knows best," "scholars know more," or "this is a test."
- Doubt is bypassed through warnings about nafs, Shaytan, arrogance, or corrupt sources.
- Abuse allegations may be redirected into adab, evidence rules, family privacy, or avoiding fitna.
- Psychological distress may be reduced to weak iman or lack of dhikr.
- Moral alarm is spiritualized as ignorance.

The strongest defense. Sunni tradition teaches humility before revelation and scholars.

The counter. Humility becomes SPIRITUAL BYPASSING when it stops moral inquiry. If "Allah knows best" is used to end a conversation about human harm, divine mystery has been used to protect human power.

Evidence grade. TAUGHT Mosque funding influence, madrasa pipelines, and gendered expectation are taught and structural rather than written.

26 · Financial Control

Extracting money through spiritual obligation while offering no transparency about where it goes.

How it shows here

- Sunni communities may financially pressure members through mosque fundraising, Islamic school tuition, scholar donations, conference fees, online courses, charity drives, and marriage costs.
- “Supporting the deen” can become a moral obligation that makes refusal feel spiritually suspect.
- Conservative communities may financially isolate members by discouraging certain careers, loans, mixed workplaces, or secular education.
- Financial dependence on family or mosque networks can make dissent dangerous.

The strongest defense. Supporting scholars, mosques, schools, and charity preserves Islamic life.

The counter. Preservation becomes FINANCIAL CONTROL when money buys religious influence or silence. If donors shape authority and the dependent cannot safely disagree, the community has made obedience economically practical.

Evidence grade. CULTURAL Major-donor influence over mosque appointments and sermon content is a widely reported pattern with no governing rule. *(sourced)*

— Stage 7 · Discard

You become expensive — too many questions, too much independence — and the urgency ramps up until you are removed.

Family withdrawal, marriage prospects closed, labeled apostate or hypocrite. In some jurisdictions, legal exposure. The community is small and total, especially in diaspora.

What it asks of you: Nothing was announced. Everything changed. That is the mechanism working correctly.

27 · Manufactured Crisis

Creating urgency to suppress critical thinking and generate loyalty.

How it shows here

- Conservative Sunni spaces may manufacture crisis through bid‘ah panic, sectarian warnings, fear of liberalism, fear of feminism, fear of ex-Muslims, and warnings against corrupt scholars.
- A believer asking questions may be treated as urgently at risk of misguidance.
- Gender boundaries are framed as crisis prevention: one conversation, outfit, friendship, or education choice could lead to fitna.
- Community leaders may use fear of deviance to centralize authority.

The strongest defense. Sunni tradition protects believers from misguidance and innovation.

The counter. Protection becomes MANUFACTURED CRISIS when ordinary inquiry is treated as spiritual emergency. If every alternative view is a threat and every question must be contained, scholarship has become crisis management.

Evidence grade. CULTURAL Costs of leaving are borne privately in family homes, which is exactly why institutions can truthfully deny imposing them.

28 · Discard

Removing members who become too costly – too many questions, too much independence, too visible a contradiction.

How it shows here

- A Sunni believer who questions approved scholars, hadith, gender law, or sectarian boundaries may be labeled deviant, arrogant, ignorant, liberal, or corrupted.
- Someone who adopts different interpretations may be treated as unsafe to follow or befriend.
- Women who reject conservative expectations may lose marriage prospects, family approval, or mosque respectability.
- The community discards dissent by redefining the dissenter as outside proper knowledge.

The strongest defense. Communities must protect correct belief and avoid misguidance.

The counter. Correct belief becomes DISCARD when disagreement makes a person socially untouchable. If the community cannot distinguish sincere dissent from corruption, scholarship has become a sorting machine.

Evidence grade. CULTURAL Costs of leaving are borne privately in family homes, which is exactly why institutions can truthfully deny imposing them.

— Stage 8 · Replace

Your seat is filled before the door shuts, and nobody is responsible for any of it because the authority was attributed to God.

There is no membership roll and no vacancy, so nothing visibly changes – which is its own kind of answer. And the authority is God's, held by scholars whose salaries come from governments they cannot criticize.

What it asks of you: Ask who pays the man whose ruling you are told is God's. The answer is a matter of public record in most of these countries.

29 · Replacement

Your seat is filled before the door closes behind you.

How it shows here

- A questioning student is replaced by one who accepts approved scholars without resistance.
- A woman who loosens dress standards is replaced in community esteem by someone stricter.
- A reform-minded member is replaced by a loyal traditionalist in teaching or leadership circles.
- The community's ideal believer becomes whoever confirms the authority structure.

The strongest defense. Communities elevate people who model correct practice.

The counter. Modeling becomes REPLACEMENT when compliant people are used to shame dissenters. If the “good Muslim” is always the one who asks fewer threatening questions, piety has become an HR category.

Evidence grade. CULTURAL Divine authority invoked by scholars whose salaries, in most jurisdictions, are a matter of public record.

30 · Plausible Deniability

The institution is never responsible, because the authority is attributed to God – who isn't available for cross-examination.

How it shows here

- Sunni institutions can say, “Follow qualified scholars,” then define “qualified” as scholars who preserve the accepted answer.
- A woman is not officially forced into a stricter standard, but family, mosque, marriage markets, and community gossip make the stricter standard socially necessary.
- A doubter is told to ask questions, but if questions persist, they are following desires, lacking adab, or listening to corrupt sources.
- Communities deny sectarian pressure while warning against deviant groups, liberals, reformers, ex-Muslims, Orientalists, feminists, or Shia sources.
- Harsh rulings are defended as scholarship when imposed, then softened as “one opinion” when criticized publicly.

The strongest defense. Sunni Islam contains scholarly diversity. Laypeople need guidance. Communities are protecting people from misguidance.

The counter. Diversity becomes PLAUSIBLE DENIABILITY when it is advertised to outsiders but narrowed for insiders. Guidance becomes guardianship when adults are never allowed to reach a dissenting conclusion. Protection from misguidance becomes protection from scrutiny when every alternative is pre-labeled dangerous.

Evidence grade. CULTURAL Divine authority invoked by scholars whose salaries, in most jurisdictions, are a matter of public record.

SECTION 13

The loops

1 · MONEY TO DOCTRINE TO MONEY

Free religious education is funded by donors who also determine the curriculum, producing graduates who staff the institutions that teach it.

2 · FEAR TO DEPENDENCE TO FEAR

Fear of apostasy and family shame installed young, relieved only by conformity, transmitted by relatives at no institutional cost.

3 · CHILDREN TO MEMBERS TO CHILDREN

Madrasa pipelines produce adults who cannot earn outside religious employment, who send their sons to the same schools.

4 · AID TO LEGITIMACY TO LEVERAGE TO AID

Exported religious infrastructure buys soft power for funding states, which sustains the funding.

5 · UNPAID LABOR TO ASSETS TO POWER TO MORE LABOR

Volunteer labor and donated land build the institution; boards and networks hold it.

6 · SCANDAL TO REMOVAL TO REFORM THEATRE TO CONTINUITY

A teacher is moved, the community closes ranks, and no reporting policy is written.

7 · PERSECUTION TO SOLIDARITY TO INSULATION TO UNACCOUNTABILITY

Anti-Muslim hostility is genuine and is used to make any internal criticism into evidence for the enemy.

SECTION 14

Say versus do

— What they say, what the record shows

THEY SAY	THE RECORD SHOWS	RECEIPT
Scholars are independent of rulers.	Colonial and modern states seized the endowments that funded independence and replaced them with salaries.	ACADEMIC SOURCE
We follow the consensus of the scholars.	The consensus cited is usually one school's position, and the disagreeing schools are not mentioned.	ACADEMIC SOURCE
Honor violence has nothing to do with Islam.	Correct, and many scholars say so plainly. The mechanism is legal, not doctrinal: where qisas-and-diyat law lets a victim's heirs pardon a killer, a family that kills one of its own can also forgive itself. Pakistan narrowed this only in 2016.	OFFICIAL POLICY · Criminal Law (Amendment) (Offences in the Name or Pretext of Honour) Act 2016, Pakistan

— Accountability or theatre?

Last time the chair ran. Madrasa abuse cases handled by relocation, with the family that reported losing standing.

Who holds the chair now. Network leaderships and state ministries with no safeguarding obligation.

Prediction. The next case will be reported by an outside journalist, the argument will be about the journalist, and the school will reopen under a new head.

— Words used here

TERM	WHAT IT MEANS INSIDE	WHAT IT DOES	SAID PLAINLY
Ijma / the consensus of the scholars	Agreement of qualified scholars, a recognised source of law.	Invoked to close questions where consensus is in fact contested – and where the scholars in question were appointed by a ministry.	'Everyone agrees, and I will not be listing who.'
Ulama / the people of knowledge	The scholarly class.	A genuine and demanding tradition of learning. The accountability question is upstream: in most of the modern world, who accredits them is a state.	'Defer to the scholars – and do not ask who appoints the scholars.'
Fitnah in the ranks	Discord raised within the community.	The specific form used against internal reformers, as distinct from external critics.	'Raising this here is the offence.'

SOURCES FOR THIS SECTION: ¹

SECTION 15

Cost & cover

— What leaving costs

- Community and family enforcement typically exceeds institutional enforcement; leaving or liberalizing costs marriage prospects, family standing, and in diaspora communities, one's entire social base. VARIES BY COMMUNITY

— The ledger of exit

COST	DOCUMENTED?	DETAIL	THE OFFICIAL DENIAL
Family rupture	Very common	Withdrawal of family, marriage prospects, and inheritance in practice	"Islam forbids compulsion in religion."
Community standing	Yes	Labeled apostate, Westernized, or a hypocrite; diaspora networks are tightly knit	"That's just people's opinions."
Legal risk	Jurisdiction-dependent	Apostasy or blasphemy statutes; personal-status consequences for custody and marriage	"Those are national laws, not religion."
Spiritual threat	Yes	Eternal punishment; family told their own salvation is implicated	"A sincere warning."

— How the cost is denied

CHANNEL	LEVEL	NOTE
Explicit policy	Medium	Legal-school rulings are published; enforcement mechanisms usually are not.
Informal enforcement	High	Family, neighborhood, and marriage-market pressure carry the load.
Leadership distance	High	No pope, no synod – no one accountable for the aggregate.
Doctrinal ambiguity	High	Any practice can be relocated to another madhhab or 'culture.'
Cultural outsourcing	High	Honor codes, FGM, and forced marriage are attributed to local custom.
Volunteer enforcement	High	Relatives and community members enforce; institutions issue nothing.
Sacred secrecy	Medium	Family honor suppresses abuse reporting decisively.
Exit cost denial	High	'No compulsion in religion' is quoted while the actual costs are borne privately.

SECTION 16

The ledger

— Who benefits

- Exporting states purchasing soft power through religious infrastructure. ACADEMIC SOURCE
- Official clerics whose salaries and platforms depend on endorsing power; media preachers monetizing piety through satellite channels and speaking fees.
- Patriarchal family structures that gain doctrine-backed authority over women's and children's choices.

PATTERN OBSERVED

— Money out, leverage back

- Decades of petro-funded mosques, schools, and free literature gave communities worldwide infrastructure they needed and an interpretation they did not select. The building is a gift; the curriculum is a condition.

ACADEMIC SOURCE

- Official grand-mufti offices issue rulings that track state policy, converting scholarship into foreign and domestic policy instruments. GOVERNMENT REPORT
- Satellite and online preachers monetize piety at scale with no scholarly accountability structure – audience size replaced ijaza as the credential. PATTERN OBSERVED

— Who pays

- Women, in guardianship, divorce, mosque access, and domestic-violence counseling.
- Children in unregulated residential madrasas.
- Independent scholars silenced for diverging from official positions.
- Doubters and ex-Muslims, who lose family and, in some states, legal safety.
- Sufi and minority communities targeted by purist movements. GOVERNMENT REPORT

SECTION 17

Who gets hurt most

— Where the weight lands

WHO	HOW	WHAT IT COMPOUNDS WITH
Women	Guardianship over marriage, mosque exclusion by architecture, domestic-violence counsel to endure	With economic dependence and no civil family law
Boys in hifz-only schooling	Adulthood with no literacy, numeracy, or employable credential	For life, and it makes exit financially impossible
Independent scholars	Suspension, travel bans, prosecution for diverging from official positions	With loss of the only career they trained for
Sufi and minority communities	Targeted by purist movements with funded infrastructure	Where the state sides with the funders
Girls whose schooling is curtailed	Withdrawn at puberty in specific contexts	Into early marriage and permanent dependence

SECTION 18

The middle tiers

ROLE	DOES	SEES	IS ASKED TO	COULD REFUSE
Local imams	Everything, for modest pay	The ministry's directives and the donor's expectations	To keep the community calm	To present a single school's ruling as the whole of Islam
Madrasa teachers	Teaches memorization to children for long hours	Which pupils are being harmed	To maintain discipline and discretion	To teach in an institution with no external reporting route
Matchmakers and family elders	Operates the marriage market that enforces most of the conformity here	Which families are being coerced	To protect reputations	To broker a marriage the woman has not freely agreed to
Community boards in the diaspora	Holds the property and hires the staff	How foreign funding arrives with expectations	To take the money	To accept funding conditioned on curriculum

SECTION 19

Documented cases

The professor declared an apostate (Egypt, 1993–1996)

WHEN: 1993–1996

WHAT: Lawyers used hisba – a suit on behalf of public morals – to have Cairo University professor Nasr Hamid Abu Zayd declared an apostate for his scholarship on the Qur'an. The Cairo Court of Appeal ordered him separated from his wife in June 1995; the Court of Cassation upheld the dissolution in August 1996. The couple left Egypt ²⁷.

RECORD: Cairo Court of Appeal (14 June 1995); Court of Cassation (1996) ²⁷

OUTCOME: Egypt narrowed hisba standing in 1996, but the ruling stood ²⁷.

TACTICS: [17 · Smear Campaign](#), [14 · Isolation](#), [28 · Discard](#)

GRADE: **DOCUMENTED**

The blasphemy death sentence overturned (Pakistan, 2010–2018)

WHEN: 2010–2018

WHAT: Asia Bibi, a Christian farmworker, was sentenced to death under s. 295-C in 2010 after a dispute with Muslim co-workers; the Lahore High Court upheld it in 2014. The Supreme Court acquitted her on 31 October 2018, finding contradictory evidence and a late complaint ²⁸.

RECORD: Supreme Court of Pakistan (31 Oct 2018); review petition dismissed Jan 2019 ²⁸

OUTCOME: Nationwide protests led by a religious party followed the acquittal; she left the country ²⁸.

TACTICS: [16 · Flying Monkeys](#), [27 · Manufactured Crisis](#), [17 · Smear Campaign](#)

GRADE: **DOCUMENTED**

A pardon for an honour killing (Pakistan, 2016–2022)

WHEN: 2016–2022

WHAT: Social-media figure Qandeel Baloch was killed by her brother in July 2016. He was sentenced to life in 2019; in February 2022 the Lahore High Court freed him after their parents pardoned him – although a 2016 law had removed the heirs' pardon for honour killings, the protection applies only when a court classifies the killing as one ¹²³.

RECORD: Lahore High Court (14 Feb 2022) ³

OUTCOME: The loophole the 2016 reform left open was used against its own headline case ²³.

TACTICS: [30 · Plausible Deniability](#), [24 · Identity Erosion](#)

GRADE: **DOCUMENTED**

The cleric detained for silence (Saudi Arabia, 2017–present)

WHEN: 2017–present

WHAT: Salman al-Awda, one of the kingdom's best-known scholars, was arrested in September 2017 after declining to publicly back the state's position on Qatar. Prosecutors sought the death penalty on 37 charges in 2018; in 2025 he remained in solitary confinement with his trial repeatedly postponed ^{13 14 51}.

RECORD: Specialized Criminal Court proceedings, as reported by Human Rights Watch and Amnesty ^{14 51}

OUTCOME: Unresolved.

TACTICS: [18 · Silent Treatment / Stonewalling](#), [17 · Smear Campaign](#), [21 · Learned Helplessness](#)

GRADE: **DOCUMENTED**

A governor jailed for blasphemy (Indonesia, 2016–2017)

WHEN: 2016–2017

WHAT: Jakarta's Christian governor, Basuki Tjahaja Purnama ("Ahok"), said voters were being deceived by the use of a Qur'anic verse against him. After mass rallies, the North Jakarta District Court convicted him of blasphemy (Art. 156a) on 9 May 2017 and sentenced him to two years – more than the prosecutors had asked for ²⁹.

RECORD: North Jakarta District Court (9 May 2017) ²⁹

OUTCOME: Served his sentence; Indonesia's 2023 Criminal Code kept a blasphemy offence ³⁰.

TACTICS: [16 · Flying Monkeys](#), [27 · Manufactured Crisis](#), [12 · DARVO](#)

GRADE: **DOCUMENTED**

The convert the civil courts would not hear (Malaysia, 2007)

WHEN: 2007

WHAT: Lina Joy, born Muslim, converted to Christianity and asked the registration department to remove "Islam" from her identity card so she could marry. The Federal Court ruled 2–1 on 30 May 2007 that only a syariah court could recognize her leaving, under Article 121(1A) ³¹.

RECORD: Federal Court of Malaysia, *Lina Joy v Majlis Agama Islam Wilayah Persekutuan* (2007) ³¹

OUTCOME: Exit from Islam in Malaysia runs through the institution being left.

TACTICS: [14 · Isolation](#), [21 · Learned Helplessness](#), [7 · Persecution to Solidarity to Insulation to Unaccountability](#)

GRADE: **DOCUMENTED**

SECTION 20

Precedent

— It has been broken before

WHAT	WHO	WHEN	WHAT IT COST
The classical tradition of scholars refusing state payroll to preserve independence	Centuries of jurists	Historic	Poverty and periodic imprisonment
Contemporary madhhab-diversity education showing restrictive rulings are contested	Traditionalist scholars and academics	Ongoing	Accusations of laxity
Locally funded mosques rejecting conditional foreign money	Diaspora congregations	Ongoing	Slower growth
Indonesia raises the minimum marriage age to 19 for both sexes	Child-marriage survivors whose petition won a 2018 Constitutional Court ruling	2019	Religious courts' dispensations for underage marriage rose sharply in the years that followed

— What would change this page

A major state-appointed council publicly ruling against its appointing government's interest – and surviving intact – would revise the capture finding this page rests on.

SOURCES FOR THIS SECTION: [4](#) [5](#)

SECTION 21

Voices from inside

- **Ahmad ibn Hanbal (780–855).** Refused the caliph's doctrinal test, was flogged and imprisoned, and did not recant; the inquisition was abandoned in 848 ⁴⁹. The tradition's own precedent for independence from the state.
- **The Indonesian Congress of Women Ulama (KUPI), 2017.** Hundreds of women scholars met in Cirebon and issued fatwas declaring child marriage harmful and its prevention obligatory, and against marital rape ³⁷.
- **Sisters in Islam and Musawah.** A Malaysian group working for women's rights from inside the Islamic framework since the 1980s; it initiated Musawah, the global movement for equality in Muslim family law, launched in Kuala Lumpur in February 2009 ^{40 41}.
- **Khaled Abou El Fadl.** A jurist trained in Egypt and Kuwait who argues, in *Speaking in God's Name* (2001), that authorities misuse divine law against women and others ³⁸.
- **Abdullahi Ahmed An-Na'im.** Argues in *Islam and the Secular State* (2008) that sharia can only be followed freely, never enforced by a state ³⁹.
- **Salman al-Awda.** A scholar whose silence on a state policy is the charge he faces ^{13 51}.
- **Nasr Hamid Abu Zayd.** Kept publishing after a court declared him an apostate ²⁷.
- **Nahdlatul Ulama.** The world's largest Muslim organization replaced its chair through a contested vote in 2021 – an internal lever that works ¹⁷.

SECTION 22

Regional variants

United Arab Emirates

APEX: Awqaf (the General Authority of Islamic Affairs, Endowments and Zakat) issues one Friday sermon for every mosque, at a time fixed nationwide since January 2026 ²⁴. The UAE Council for Fatwa, formed in 2018 and chaired by Abdallah bin Bayyah, is the official fatwa authority and supervises fatwas by other bodies ²¹.

LAW: Blasphemy is a crime (Art. 312, 2021 Crimes and Penalties Law) ^{19 20}. Hudud – the basis for a death sentence for apostasy – were removed from the penal code in 2020 ²⁰. The 2024 Personal Status Law (in force April 2025) sets marriage at 18, lets a court marry an adult woman over her guardian's objection, and extends maternal custody to 18 ^{22 23}.

DOCUMENTED: Reform by decree, fast and real – and the sermon, the fatwa and the family court all sit inside government ^{21 22 24}.

EXIT: The law punishes public acts – offending Islam's beliefs or rites in public – so disclosure, not belief, is the legal event ^{19 20}.

REGULATOR: Federal and emirate courts; Awqaf; for abuse, the Dubai Foundation for Women and Children, 24-hour helpline 800111 ⁴⁶.

TELL: The Gulf's most reform-minded family law and its most centralized pulpit are the same fact: the reforms arrive by decree, and so could their reversal.

Saudi Arabia

APEX: Grand Mufti Saleh al-Fawzan, appointed by royal order on 22 October 2025, chairs the Council of Senior Scholars, whose members sit by royal appointment ¹⁰.

LAW: Apostasy can carry the death penalty ⁵⁰. Women over 21 may obtain passports and travel without a guardian's permission since 2019 ²⁵.

DOCUMENTED: Detention of clerics from 2017, including one facing a death-penalty prosecution ^{13 14 51}.

EXIT: The highest legal risk on this page.

REGULATOR: No independent body; UN human-rights experts report on it ⁶⁰.

TELL: When the fatwa chair is filled by royal order, "the scholars say" and "the state says" are one sentence.

Egypt

APEX: The Grand Imam of al-Azhar, elected by its Council of Senior Scholars and irremovable under the 2014 Constitution ^{8 9}.

LAW: The principles of sharia are the main source of legislation (Art. 2); "contempt of religion" carries up to five years (Art. 98(f)) ^{8 26}.

DOCUMENTED: Blasphemy prosecutions of converts and Christians continued into 2026 ²⁶; a court once dissolved a scholar's marriage for apostasy ²⁷.

EXIT: No criminal penalty, but personal-status law follows religion – as a court showed when it dissolved a scholar's marriage ²⁷.

REGULATOR: The courts, which are also the enforcement route ^{26 27}.

TELL: The only irremovable Sunni chair on this page sits in a state that prosecutes blasphemy – independence of the office is not freedom of the believer.

Turkey

APEX: The Diyanet, headed by Safi Arpaguş since September 2025 ¹¹.

LAW: A secular constitution with a state religious presidency; the Diyanet's budget is a line in the state budget ^{32 33}; insulting religious values carries up to a year (Art. 216(3)) ⁶¹.

DOCUMENTED: Budget of £174.4bn for 2026 ³³ and a domestic network of some 90,000 mosques ¹².

EXIT: No legal penalty; costs are social and familial.

REGULATOR: Parliament votes the budget; that is the lever ^{32 33}.

TELL: A secular republic runs one of the largest mosque payrolls in the world – and publishes it, which is more than most religious bodies do.

Pakistan

APEX: No single mufti; the state's religious courts and councils share authority.

LAW: Mandatory death sentence for defiling the Prophet's name (s. 295-C) ²⁸. Honour killings: the 2016 law removed the heirs' pardon, but only where a court classifies the killing as honour-based ¹².

DOCUMENTED: The Asia Bibi acquittal (2018) and the Qandeel Baloch pardon (2022) ^{3 28}.

EXIT: Very high legal risk; even the 2018 acquittal was met with nationwide protests ²⁸.

REGULATOR: The superior courts – which acquitted Asia Bibi – are the working check ²⁸.

TELL: The highest court overturned a blasphemy death sentence, and the country shut down in protest. The law is only half the machinery; the crowd is the other half.

Indonesia

APEX: No state mufti; MUI issues fatwas, and the two mass organizations elect their leaders ^{6 17 18}.

LAW: The 2023 Criminal Code (in force January 2026) keeps blasphemy (up to 3 years) and adds up to 2 years for publicly inciting others to have no religion ³⁰. Minimum marriage age 19 since 2019 ⁴.

DOCUMENTED: Religious courts' dispensations for underage marriage rose from 23,126 (2019) to 64,211 (2020) ⁵; a governor jailed for blasphemy in 2017 ²⁹.

EXIT: Legally possible between recognised religions; atheism is socially and legally exposed ³⁰.

REGULATOR: Religious courts, the Constitutional Court (which heard child brides' petition), and Komnas Perempuan ^{4 5}.

TELL: The world's largest Muslim country has the world's largest Muslim organizations that elect their leaders – and a religious court that grants tens of thousands of child-marriage dispensations.

Malaysia

APEX: State religious councils and muftis; the rulers of each state are heads of Islam there.

LAW: Syariah courts have exclusive jurisdiction over Muslims' religious status (Art. 121(1A)) ³¹.

DOCUMENTED: *Lina Joy* (2007) ³¹; a free legal clinic for Muslim women (Telenisa) has run since 2003 ⁴¹.

EXIT: Only through the syariah court.

REGULATOR: Syariah courts; Sisters in Islam's Telenisa for legal advice ⁴¹.

TELL: A constitution that guarantees freedom of religion sends the question of leaving to the courts of the religion being left.

United Kingdom

APEX: None; mosques are independent charities, and sharia councils are voluntary.

LAW: An independent review in 2018 recommended civil registration of religious marriages so women are not left without legal status ⁵³.

DOCUMENTED: Honour-based abuse is handled as a crime; a specialist helpline supports victims ⁴⁴.

EXIT: Legally free; socially costly in close communities. Support exists for people leaving ⁴².

REGULATOR: The Charity Commission for mosques registered as charities; the police for honour-based abuse ⁴⁴.

TELL: The same school of law, in a jurisdiction where the state neither appoints the imam nor enforces the fatwa: the costs of leaving fall back to family.

SECTION 23

The questions

1. If a scholar's salary is paid by a government, on what basis would you ever distinguish his fatwa from that government's press release?
2. Why can a boy leave a madrasa at eighteen unable to earn a living outside religious employment – and who benefits from that being true?
3. The Hanafi school permits a woman to contract her own marriage. Why does your community not, and who decided?
4. Scholars across the schools condemn honor killing as murder. Yet until 2016 Pakistani law let a victim's heirs pardon the killer – and when the killer is family, the heirs are the family. Why did closing that route take until 2016, and why does it still depend on a court classifying the killing as “honor”?
5. If a child was beaten or abused in a religious school, was it reported to police? If not, whom did the silence protect?
6. You were taught that raising these things helps the enemies of Islam. Ask who taught you that, and what their silence bought them.

— In closing

The thing your tradition should be proudest of is precisely what has been taken: scholars who could not be bought because rulers did not pay them. Everything in this profile is a departure from that inheritance. Asking for it back is not modernism.

You can love the Sunnah and refuse a paid cleric's politics. You can revere scholarship and still ask who signs the cheque. That is not weak faith; that is the classical tradition's own standard, applied to the people currently claiming it.

SOURCES FOR THIS SECTION: 1 2

SECTION 24

Leaving safely here

This is practical guidance, not legal advice. Where you are matters more than what you believe – read the Law & state table first.

1. **Check your jurisdiction.** In some countries on this page leaving, or saying so, is a crime; in others it is legally free ^{20 26 28 30 50}.
2. **Do not announce.** The laws on this page punish public acts – declaring, insulting, inciting – so disclosure, not belief, is usually the legal event ^{19 26 30}.
3. **Secure documents and money first.** Passport, identity documents, and a bank account in your own name – in Saudi Arabia, women over 21 may now hold their own passport ²⁵.
4. **Know your family-law exposure.** Marriage and custody often follow religion: a court dissolved one scholar's marriage for apostasy, and Malaysia routes the question to syariah courts ^{27 31}. Take legal advice before any disclosure if children are involved.
5. **Plan for your safety if honour is invoked.** Specialist services exist for forced marriage and honour-based abuse ^{44 46}.
6. **Find your people quietly.** Vetted private communities for ex-Muslims exist, and so do helplines for Muslims who are staying ^{42 43 45}.

SECTION 25

Where to get help

Checked 2026-09-27. Numbers and services change; check the organization's own site.

ORGANIZATION	FOR	WHERE	CONTACT
Dubai Foundation for Women and Children	Domestic violence, child abuse, trafficking; emergency shelter	UAE	24-hour helpline 800111 ; SMS 5111 ⁴⁶
Karma Nirvana	Honour-based abuse and forced marriage	UK	Helpline 0800 5999 247 ⁴⁴
Faith to Faithless (Humanists UK)	People leaving high-control religion, including Islam	UK	Helpline and peer support ⁴²
Ex-Muslims of North America	Vetted private communities; emergency fund	US, Canada	Online application ⁴³
Naseeha	Muslim peer mental-health helpline (for people staying, too)	North America	1-866-627-3342 , call or text, 24/7 ⁴⁵
Sisters in Islam – Telenisa	Free legal advice on Islamic family law for women	Malaysia	Legal clinic, Tue–Thu ⁴¹
Musawah	Equality in Muslim family law; research and advocacy	Global	Online ⁴⁰
Humanists International – Humanists at Risk	People facing prosecution for apostasy or blasphemy	Global	Casework ⁵²

SECTION 26

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(Standard chronology – the four legal schools' founders, Abu Hanifa d. 767, Malik d. 795, al-Shafi'i d. 820, Ibn Hanbal d. 855; al-Bukhari d. 870 and Muslim d. 875; the Saudi–Wahhabi pact of 1744; the Muslim Brotherhood founded 1928 – is uncontroversial and is cited to the *Encyclopaedia Britannica* entries on each: <https://www.britannica.com/topic/Sunni>)

SECTION 27

What changed on this page

- **2026-09-27 – fact-check pass 1:** al-Azhar's Grand Imam is elected and irremovable, not state-appointed; Diyanet head named (Safi Arpaguş) and mosque count updated; population corrected to 1.7–1.8 billion; the "trail ends at a ministry every time" line softened.
- **2026-09-27 – full page:** added Branches, Law & state, Money in numbers, six documented cases, Voices from inside, eight regional cards, Leaving safely and Where to get help; the 1961 al-Azhar turning point now notes the 2012 change.